

Impact: High Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Medium

WHY IT WORKS

People conflate being understood with being agreed with — but they are separate. Showing someone you have genuinely heard their position reduces defensiveness, even before you express a different view.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not a softer way of agreeing — the disagreement survives, at full strength.
- Not 'I hear you' as a formality before steamrolling — the acknowledgement has to be real.
- It is holding two truths at once: their experience is real, and your reading is different.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: I can be completely upset with them and still feel respected by them.

Principle: People fight hardest when their reality is denied — validate the experience and the fight loses most of its fuel.

What you gain

- Conflicts that cool without you conceding anything
- A reputation for fairness even among people who disagree with you
- Positions that hold under emotional pressure
- Relationships that survive genuine disagreement
- Fewer arguments about whether feelings are 'allowed'

Why most people fail at it

- They treat validating the feeling as losing the argument.
- They cave on the substance to stop the discomfort, then resent it.
- Their validation arrives with a 'but' that cancels it.
- Under heat, they defend the facts and trample the feeling.

CORE FORMULA

Acknowledge their experience -> Make clear you are not agreeing with the claim -> Hold both

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say 'I can see why you feel that way' before 'I don't agree with that.' Both sentences. In that order.

BEST FOR

- Conflict situations where emotions are high
- Feedback that is partly emotional and partly factual
- Responding to distress without conceding accuracy
- Maintaining a position while keeping the relationship intact

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Acknowledge — Honour the experience first

Name their feeling as real and understandable — fully, without a qualifying clause. This is the sentence they are listening for; until it lands, nothing else you say gets in.

Hedged: 'I suppose that could be frustrating for some people.'

Full: 'That clearly landed badly, and the frustration makes sense.'

2. Distinguish — Mark the boundary

Make explicit that hearing the feeling is not agreeing with the claim. Without this line, validation is heard as concession — and retracting it later is expensive.

Blurred: 'Yeah, no, totally, I mean, you are probably right...'

Marked: 'And at the same time, I read the situation differently.'

3. Hold — Keep both true under pressure

When they push — and they will — repeat both halves rather than sacrificing one. Dropping the validation turns you cold; dropping the position turns you dishonest.

Sacrificing: 'Fine, fine, you are right, forget I said anything.'

Holding: 'I still believe both things: it hurt, and I made the right call.'

FIELD TIP

Separate the two sentences and say both.

The move fails when the validation and the disagreement blur into one hedge. Give each its own full sentence: the feeling, honoured; the position, held. The order matters — feeling first.

Situation: Your partner says you embarrassed them at dinner.

Don't: 'Well I am sorry IF it felt that way, but honestly nobody even noticed.'

Do: 'It clearly stung, and I take that seriously. I genuinely do not think it read that way to the table — can I say why?'

PHRASE BANK

Validation Without Agreement · Acknowledging without conceding

- "I can see why that would feel that way."
- "That experience sounds genuinely frustrating — and..."
- "I understand why you are angry, and I still see it differently."
- "Your feeling is real. My read of the situation is different."
- "I hear the concern — I do not share the conclusion."
- "That experience makes sense. The interpretation I would put on it is different."
- "I am not dismissing how that landed — I just do not agree with the claim."
- "Both of those things can be true: that it felt bad, and that I acted correctly."

Holding Both · Keeping validation and your position simultaneously

- "I can hold both of those at once."
- "Your experience is real and I see it differently."
- "I am not saying you are wrong to feel that. I am saying I see it differently."
- "Neither of us is wrong — we are describing different things."
- "The feeling is valid. The conclusion I would draw from it is different."

Close Relationships · Partners, family and friends

- "It matters to me that it hurt, even though I would do the same again."
- "I love you, I believe you about the feeling, and I remember it differently."
- "You do not have to convince me it was hard for you — I can see that part."
- "I want to take care of the feeling first and argue about the facts later."
- "We can disagree about what happened and still be on the same side."

Workplace Version · Feedback, decisions and reviews

- "Your reading of the situation is understandable from where you sat. Mine differs, and I want to show you why."
- "I take the impact seriously, and I stand by the decision."
- "The experience you are describing is real. The intent you are inferring is not what happened."
- "I can acknowledge how the process felt without agreeing it was unfair."
- "Two things are true: the communication was poor, and the call itself was right."

Holding in the Heat · When agreeing would end the conflict — dishonestly

- "I am not going to pretend to agree just to end this — you would see through it anyway."

- "I can keep hearing the anger, and it will not change my answer."
- "Do not mistake my calm for concession."
- "I respect the strength of feeling. I am not persuaded by it."
- "If I caved now, you would not trust my agreement next time either."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Dismissing the emotion: 'That is not what happened'
Better: I do not think that is quite right.
Best: I can see why it felt that way — and my read of what happened is different.
2. Weak: Agreeing to end the conflict: 'You are right, I was wrong'
Better: I can see why you are frustrated.
Best: Validate the feeling cleanly. Then state your position clearly. Hold both.
3. Weak: Validating in a tone that implies sarcasm
Better: I understand.
Best: Genuine acknowledgement of their experience, then a clear, neutral statement of your view.

DECISION TREE

If Someone is upset and making a claim you disagree with

Validate the emotion first. Separate it from the factual claim.

"I can see this is really frustrating. My read of what happened is different."

If They interpret validation as agreement and press harder

Clarify the distinction.

"I want to be clear — I am not saying you are right about X. I am saying I understand why you feel that way."

If Their claim contains truth and error

Validate the true part. Correct only the error.

"The part you have right is X. The part I see differently is Y."

If You validate and they feel dismissed anyway

Ask what they need to feel heard.

"I want to make sure I am hearing you fully — what am I missing?"

SCENARIOS

Direct report feels unfairly treated by a decision

Validate the feeling without conceding the decision was wrong. — "I can see why that landed as unfair — and I stand behind the decision. Let me explain why."

Partner upset about something you did

Acknowledge the impact before defending the intention. — "I can see it hurt — that was not my intention, and I also want to understand why it hit that way."

Client is angry about a service outcome

Validate the frustration before correcting the factual misunderstanding. — "That experience sounds genuinely frustrating. I want to clear up what actually happened."

Colleague says you were unfair in a meeting

Validate that their experience was real before presenting your view. — "I hear that it felt that way. I saw it differently — can I share my perspective?"

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Colleague: I think we need to completely restructure the team.

You: No — that's way too drastic.

Colleague: (digs in harder, feels dismissed)

With the technique

You: I hear why you're at that point — the current structure has made things harder than they should be. I want to understand more before I react. Can you walk me through what's breaking?
Colleague: Yes — here's what's been happening.

COMMON MISTAKES

The cancelling 'but'

Sounds like: 'I understand you are upset, but...'

Better: 'I understand you are upset. And I see the facts differently.'

The conditional apology

Sounds like: 'I am sorry IF you were offended.'

Better: 'It clearly hurt. That part I take seriously, whatever we decide about the rest.'

Conceding to end the discomfort

Sounds like: 'Okay, okay, you are right, I am sorry.'

Better: 'I am not going to agree just to close this down — you deserve a real answer.'

Litigating the feeling

Sounds like: 'You should not feel that way — that is irrational.'

Better: 'The feeling is yours and it is real. The claim attached to it is what I want to talk about.'

Validation with a courtroom tone

Sounds like: 'Your emotional response is noted.'

Better: Say it like a human: 'That obviously hurt. I get it.'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- The other person feels heard without you having conceded the point.
- Emotional conversations de-escalate rather than escalate.
- Your position is still standing at the end of the conversation.
- You feel genuine rather than strategic in how you validated.

Signs to adjust

- Validation sounds sarcastic or hollow.
- They interpret validation as agreement every time.
- You end up conceding the point anyway despite validating.
- The technique feels like emotional manipulation rather than genuine acknowledgement.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When validation is impossible to offer genuinely — offering it dishonestly will be detected.
- When urgency means you need to express your view immediately and pausing to validate would delay a critical decision.
- When the person's position is based on factual errors that your validation might inadvertently reinforce.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I started arguing with your feelings instead of hearing them. The feelings were never the dispute.'

- "That 'but' cancelled the first half of my sentence. Both halves were true."
- "I started arguing with your feelings instead of hearing them. The feelings were never the dispute."
- "I went cold there — holding my position does not require that."
- "I agreed with you a minute ago just to end it, and it was not honest. Can I try again?"
- "Let me redo that: first the part where I hear you, properly, and then my view."
- "I dismissed the experience while disputing the claim. Only one of those was fair."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Hold-the-line chain

Validate the feeling -> mark the boundary -> state the position -> reopen warmth

I can see how much this decision hurt, and I am not brushing that off.

Hearing that is not the same as agreeing it was wrong.

I still believe it was the right call, and I will show you the reasoning whenever you want it.

Whatever you think of the decision, I want us to be all right.

Feedback chain

Validate their reading -> distinguish intent from impact -> own the impact -> hold the substance

From where you sat, I can see how it looked like I went around you.

That was not the intent — and impact counts, so let me own that part.

The way it was communicated was poor, and that is on me.

The decision itself I stand behind, and I am happy to walk through it.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC014 — Validate the Concern

Validate the Concern is the everyday version — for concerns you can largely accept rather than claims you must dispute.

TC007 — Disagreement Without Contempt

Disagreement Without Contempt governs the second sentence — how to hold your position without a sneer.

TC017 — Agreement Before Disagreement

Agreement Before Disagreement finds the true common ground first, which makes the 'different reading' easier to hear.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Separate emotion from claim

In one conversation today, notice when someone's emotion and factual claim are different things. Do not respond yet — just notice.

Day 2 — Validate first

In one disagreement, validate the emotion before saying anything about the facts.

Day 3 — The clean distinction

Practise saying: 'I understand why you feel that way — and I see the situation differently.' In that order.

Day 4 — Hold both

In one conversation, explicitly say that both the feeling and your different view can be true at once.

Day 5 — The hard case

Use this with someone who is very upset and whose factual claim you believe is wrong.

Day 6 — Check for sincerity

After each validation, ask yourself: was that genuine? Or was it a technique to smooth the conversation?

Day 7 — Calibration

Did conversations de-escalate? Did you hold your position? Did any validation feel hollow or manipulative?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I acknowledge their experience before stating my position?
- Did I separate their emotion from their factual claim?
- Was my validation genuine — not a tactic to soften them up?
- Did I still state my position clearly after validating?
- Did I make clear I was validating the feeling, not agreeing with the claim?
- Did the conversation de-escalate?
- Did I hold my position without becoming cold or defensive?